The Descent of Tang and the Ascent of the Sung Dynasty

Despite the amazing achievements that came about during the Tang Dynasty, there still existed resentment towards the government and various rebellions broke out. In 755 CE, the An Lushan Rebellion broke out causing the death of thousands. An Lushan was a general and much-loved by the imperial court. After poisoning the minds of the people at court, he staged a revolt against the government. He led more than 100,000 men in a military coup and announced that he was the new Emperor. In 763 CE, An Lushan was overthrown but the damage had been done. A series of other uprisings occurred in a domino effect and lots of people were killed.

The population decreased dramatically. Scholars have estimated that around 36,000,000 people died from internal revolts. Because trading networks were becoming diminished and taxes were not being collected, the Imperial Court abandoned the capital at Chang'an and headed for safety elsewhere. After another rebellion occurred between 874 and 884 CE, the Tang Dynasty began to decline. In 907 CE, the dynasty collapsed completely and splintered off into various states, all of which declared themselves to be legitimate dynasties. This period is known as the Five Dynasties and Ten Kingdoms Period (907 – 960 CE). China remained divided until the founding of the Sung or Song Dynasty (960 – 1279 CE).

During the Song Dynasty, China began to experience stability again. New laws, organizations and practices were introduced to create a more just society. Neo-Confucianism had become the main philosophy that went on to influence all aspects of government and culture. However, the usual arguments between the affluent landowners and the peasantry continued. One could say they continue up until today because the poor are unhappy with the low wages they receive and the rich continue to get richer in China.